

Megha Engineering & Infrastructures Limited, makes his role with ABCPL very clear. "I took over the business six to seven years ago. I am completely hands-off and like any of my other businesses, it is left to a bunch of competent professionals," he says. Interestingly, it was acquired not much before the General Elections of 2019, and the assembly polls in Andhra Pradesh and Telangana. "I wanted to be in media then. I saw an opportunity and decided to invest to grow it," explains Reddy. Prior to exiting the business, Raju was in negotiations with other prominent media houses before zeroing in on Alanda.

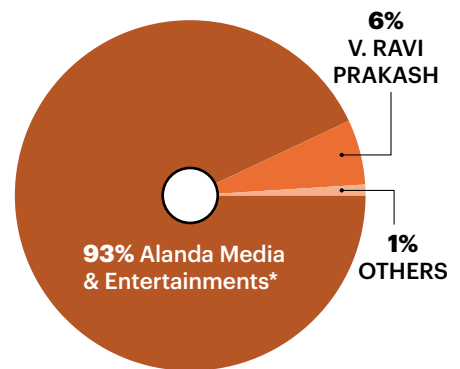
"We are a large network today, but I have never used that for other businesses. In fact, I have not given them a single interview to date," emphasises Reddy. With a holding of around 40% in Alanda (according to Reddy), he drives home the point of his non-involvement in the business. "What takes my time is technology in other ventures

and ways to bring that to India. I don't even sit on the board of Associated Broadcasting Company." According to the company's annual report for FY23, the shareholding of Alanda Media in ABCPL was 93.44%, with Ravi Prakash and others accounting for the rest. Of the 93.44%, more than 50% is with the promoters of My Home Constructions, a well-known name in Hyderabad's real estate business, which was founded by Jupally Rameswar Rao.

Srinivasa Raju, who spent many years in the US, tells *BT* he was intrigued by how cities like Los Angeles and San Diego each had three to four television news channels. "The opportunity to do something similar in a diverse Indian market was obvious," he says. There are around 20 news channels in Telugu today with many of them having political affiliations. "The turning point was when I started getting calls from parties to air a certain kind of a story. It was clear that running a neutral channel was going to be difficult and I de-

TV9 SHAREHOLDING PATTERN

► Investments by the promoters of MEIL and My Home give the company financial backing ► MEIL promoters hold around 40% in the SPV Alanda Media



*60% OF ALANDA MEDIA IS HELD BY THE PROMOTERS OF MY HOME CONSTRUCTIONS

NOTE TV9 NETWORK IS OWNED BY ASSOCIATED BROADCASTING COMPANY; ANNUAL REPORT DISCLOSES NAMES OF SHAREHOLDERS WITH MORE THAN 5% IN THE COMPANY
SOURCE ASSOCIATED BROADCASTING COMPANY ANNUAL REPORT (SOURCED FROM ROC)

where it won a \$648-million contract last September for a crude oil refinery. "We went through a regular bidding process, and ours was the lowest. It was 30-40% lower than the next bid," he says. Each part of the infrastructure business interests him, whether it is hydrocarbons, roads, or anything else on MEIL's plate. "Our prices are always competitive, and we want to own them. With many global bids today, it becomes even more necessary to get it right on price."

"We have the capabilities and zeal. Of course, we will take risks and will also fail sometimes," he says. In many ways, the chutzpah of the infrastructure player in this

part of the world often comes to the fore during the chat.

So, when we mention how challenging the business can be at various levels, Reddy smiles and confidently says there is a solution for each problem. "Without a problem, there is no solution. At Megha, our success lies in finding a solution." Some food for thought.

TECHNOLOGY AND MORE TECHNOLOGY

In 2018, MEIL acquired a 50.01% stake in the listed Olectra Greentech, which makes electric buses. Reddy